the U.S. government was in fact planning for both the invasion that took place at the Bay of Pigs in April 1961, and the assassination of Fidel Castro.[35] Eisenhower's comment was made over a month after Dulles had approved the CIA recommendation for the "elimination" of Castro, and just a day after the first CIA Special Group meeting to discuss "covert contingency planning to accomplish the fall of the Castro government."[36]

Covert War: Up to the Bay of Pigs

The covert war aimed explicitly "to bring about the replacement of the Castro regime." This "replacement" must take place "in such a manner as to avoid any appearance of U.S. intervention. Essentially the method of accomplishing this end will be induced support, and so far as possible, direct action, both inside and outside of Cuba, by selected groups of Cubans of a sort that they might be expected to and could undertake on their own initiative."[37] The program was practically designed to make the Cuban government suspicious of any organized dissent in their country.

Attacks against Cuba began in late 1959, after U.S. officials had determined that the Castro government was "not the kind worth saving."[38] In January 1960 U.S. officials continued to insist publicly that "the United States is eager to promote better relations with the Castro regime," and emphatically denied Castro's claims that some 30 bombing raids by U.S.-based planes had destroyed 225,000 tons of sugar. They could not deny the evidence, however, when a U.S. plane loaded with explosives crashed over the España sugar mill outside of Havana in February 1960, and Castro appeared on television with the passport of the pilot, U.S. citizen Robert Ellis Frost. The *New York Times* noted regretfully that the incident "was an embarrassment to the United States Government" and "lent considerable weight to numerous past charges by Cuba that planes from this country had been setting fire to sugar cane fields on the island." Maps on the dead pilot's body